
A Comprehensive Guide to

Grade Seven Novella

Strange Happenings

Jennie Marima

One Planet

This Guide is Written by

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Foreward

This Guide, written by a distinguished literary critic and author, Mr Gilbert Sigei, is one of the latest literary curriculum support materials for the junior secondary learners. The educator has demonstrated his expertise by understanding and providing a solution to the challenges facing both the junior school facilitator and the learner in navigating the dynamics of literary analysis.

In this comprehensive Guide, Mr. Sigei unravels the complexities of Jennie Marima’s novella ***Strange Happenings***, a captivating story about two learners engulfed in dilemma at Pweza Academy. The Guide helps young readers and learners to analyse texts using activities entrenched in the Inquiry-Based Learning (IBL) approaches.

Through his wealth of experience in crafting guides for secondary school set-book literature, the author gives both the teacher and learner insightful and in-depth analysis starting from the familiar to the unknown. Meticulous examination of ***Strange Happenings*** by Jennie Marima offers a roadmap for understanding, awakening and inspiring the development of critical thinking and problem-solving skills among the junior learners.

If properly used, this Guide will immensely impact your literary appreciation and spur the necessary impetus for the next levels of intensive reading. Remember after reading short stories,

and now, the novella, you are preparing yourself for the novel. The novella is a precursor and prelude to the whole world of literature ahead of you.

Introduction to the novella or novelette

How do you navigate the dynamics of the novella?

In primary School, you read various story books, class readers and comprehension passages about various issues in our daily lives. The stories are always a reflection of what happens in our society. Some stories can make you happy while others can make you feel sad. While some stories can fascinate you, others may horrify you. Valuable life lessons are embedded in the stories. Besides, one clear thing about the stories is that they are usually short. Although these stories may not be necessarily true, they represent the encounters of real life experiences in our day-to-day life.

Hence, expanding your reading resources can immensely enhance your knowledge, enrich your insights and broaden your intellect. It is essential to dedicate your time and cultivate a habit of reading a diverse range of books to learn more about various human experiences in life. As a matter of fact, reading offers the opportunity to appreciate and share experiences, change attitudes, correct behaviour, uphold moral rectitude and improve lives in a positive way. To foster personal growth and broaden your horizons, consider using your leisure time to immerse yourself in the world of literature. By reading, you will deepen your understanding of the world.

In Junior Secondary, you are going to read and learn more about an interesting but longer story: the novella. Remember intensive reading promotes better writing. This guide will help you to read interpretively, understand the text and enjoy your analysis of the novella.

A thorough analysis of the novella would require two broad aspects: intensive reading and serious writing. After reading the novella text for your literary appreciation, you will need to demonstrate deep understanding by writing a good essay.

The selected novella for your intensive reading section is ***Strange Happenings*** by Jennie Marima, a prose fictional story published by One Planet. **Jennie Marima** is a young Kenyan author who has published many storybooks in the children's category including *The High Road*, *Super Sara*, *Just This One* and *Lost Baby*.

Through a linear plot and its relatable characters, Mwawasi and his younger sister, Chao, you will be glued from the beginning to the end to discover how the younger sibling becomes her brother's keeper despite the differences in their likes and dislikes: one gifted in academic excellence while the other is endowed in sports.

However, there arises a problem and many more problems turning and twisting into strange happenings. As you read to find out more about them, this Guide will help you.

Subject general learning outcomes

By the end of the Junior School level, the learner should be able to:

1. listen and respond appropriately to relevant information in a variety of contexts,
2. read a wide variety of texts fluently, accurately, and interpretively for lifelong learning,
3. develop critical thinking skills for life,
4. read and analyse literary material and relate them to real-life experiences,
5. develop a lifelong interest in reading a wide range of subjects,
6. use grammatical forms to communicate appropriately in different settings,
7. write texts legibly, creatively, and cohesively to empower them for life
8. apply digital literacy skills to enhance proficiency in English,
9. appreciate the role of English as a medium for creativity and talent development.

Important notes for the teacher and the learner

It is important to guide learners carefully and patiently in order to eventually inspire them into liking the literature they are reading. As a facilitator, you need to start with the basics. For instance, introduce learners to the basic elements of literature such as short stories, fiction and nonfiction, poetry and drama. Then, make them familiar with simple structures like the beginning, middle, chapters and the end.

Guide learners to identify the settings, that is, the time and place of the story. Finally help learners to understand how language is used through features of style such as dialogue, simile, metaphor, flashback and exaggeration. The following approaches and notes can help you.

Preparation – it is important to read the novella in order to familiarize yourself with the text, specific learning outcomes and the Key Inquiry Questions. You can make lesson notes with the help of this guide and consider learners with special needs and varied abilities.

Brainstorming – guide the learners to think and generate ideas for the interpretation and analysis of the novella.

Discussion Groups – organise your learners to work in pairs, groups or as a class.

Making notes– ask learners to always write the main points of the text they have read.

Question and answer – use oral questions to encourage inquiry and delve more into the novella.

Dictionary – encourage learners to look up the meanings of new words. Advise them to use contextual clues to understand the meaning. The dictionary should be used as a last resort.

Role play – guide learners to perform simple roles, skits and acts based on the novella.

Dialogues – guide learners to act out conversation parts of the novella.

Writing – direct learners to write short essays, dialogues, diaries and personal journals based on the novella. They can also write articles and essays for the school newsletter and magazine to reinforce their memory.

Suggested teaching and learning resources

- **Grade 7 approved Novella** – in this case, use *Strange Happenings*.
- **Comprehensive Novella Guide** by Climax publishers.
- **Charts and pictures** showing the setting, characters and different scenes.
- **Flashcards** showing adjectives that describe the character traits, characters, themes and style.
- **Videos** showing events happening during different times.
- **Digital devices** such as mobile phones, tablets and computers.
- **Stationery** to highlight and note down the key points while reading the novella. You may underline or circle important issues, characters and style.

Strategies for the facilitator to guide the learner

Motivate and stimulate : Engage learners in discussions about the novella.

Brainstorm and discuss : Ask open-ended questions about the characters, settings, and themes to encourage critical thinking and comprehension. Encourage them to express their thoughts and feelings about the novella.

Explore and discover : Think and critically and analyse the events in the novella. Focus on the structure of story including the introduction of characters and settings, the development of plot, and the resolution of conflict.

Apply and practice : Encourage learners to practice the admirable and desirable morals and virtues. Turn away from the vices and evils in the story. Rebuke the ills.

Create and innovate : Use visual aids such as story maps and graphic organizers to help learners understand and visualize the structure and setting of a story. Use descriptive language to encourage learners to imagine themselves in that place and time.

Disseminate and share

: Encourage learners to discuss, share and present their findings about, settings, styles, themes, characters, and other techniques in class. This will promote collaboration and help learner to develop a strong foundation in understanding literature genres, culminating in lifelong love of reading and learning.

Assess the learner

: Prepare different assessment tools to determine how competencies, skills, values and knowledge have been achieved.

Keep a diary

: Guide learners to keep a diary on what the sections they expect to read or are currently reading.

Keep a journal

: Advise learners to keep a journal of what they have already read.

Effective reading strategies for the learner

- Set targets, create time and make a timetable for reading the novella.
- Always organize yourself by getting a note book and a pen.
- Write the title and the author of the novella.
- Read silently unless you are pronouncing new words. This speeds up your reading.
- Avoid pointing fingers, moving your head and re-reading parts of the text.
- Practice pronunciation of new words and look up meanings if needed.
- Highlight important parts and underline main points. □ Summarize key points and take breaks as you read.

Reading a novella

2 lessons

Key inquiry questions

1. What is a novella?
2. How can you ensure that you benefit from a reading session?
3. Why should we not judge a book by its cover?
4. What would you consider when selecting a storybook to read?

Specific Learning Outcomes for reading the novella By

the end the analysis, the learner should be able to:

- a) Explain the different parts that aid in previewing a book,
- b) Describe the author and the setting of the text in terms of time and place,
- c) Underscore the value of reading for lifelong learning.

What is a novella?**Activity 1 – work in groups**

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Insert a picture showing a learner reading a novella with the given title. Place other types of books like Bible, dictionary, storybook, other books beside.

1. Look at the picture and name the books you can see.
2. Identify the selected novella for your reading.
3. Which book shows a novella?
4. How would you describe a novella in terms of length or size?
5. Discuss and share your experiences about reading a novella.

Key Learning Insights:

- A **novella** is a short novel. It is a short fictional work of art that is divided into shorter parts called chapters. A novella is a special and interesting story that is neither too short nor too long. A novella or novelette has a simple setting, relatable themes, fewer characters, shorter chapters and basically linear plot. The novella is about 40,000 words long, usually less than 100 pages.
- A novella is written in continuous prose. This means that the story builds up from sentence to sentence, making up paragraphs. Then it continues to grow from paragraph to paragraph, making up a chapter. The chapters form part of the story which lengthens into a novella. This is called **continuous prose**. The events in the story or novella are organized in a sequence called **plot**.
- The structure of the novella is also simple: the beginning, the middle and the end.
- The author's desire in the novella is to address some of the pertinent and cross-cutting issues in society like friendship, family, health, safety and courage. Others may include adventure, fear and worry, change, decision-making, self-confidence, role-modeling, leadership, kindness, empathy and sympathy.
- The author of the novella uses language descriptively and figuratively to make the story captivating, engaging and inspiring. Through dialogue and description, the learner will find relatable characters and themes that will encourage appreciation of the moral values in the story. For instance, the strange happenings in this novella will foster critical thinking, safety risk-reduction and problem-solving skills in learners.

Did you know readers are writers?

Keep a record or journal while reading your novella.

Ask your parents which story book, novella or novel they have ever read and enjoyed. Let them share with you what they remember most about the book they read.

What is the value of reading a novella for lifelong learning? – 2 lessons

Activity 2 – work in groups

1. Do you like reading stories?
2. How do you feel when reading interesting stories?

3. How do you feel when reading shocking or terrifying stories?
4. What do you find interesting in the stories you read?
5. Can you read a very long story? Explain your answer.
6. Do you comprehend the stories you read? How do you know this?
7. How would you apply the lessons in the stories in your day-to-day life?
8. Have you ever read a novella?
9. Read the novella, ***Strange Happenings*** by Jennie Marima and discuss the ideas in it.
10. Share with your friends what you have read and enjoyed from the novella.

Activity 3 work in pairs

1. Look at the picture on page 3, 10, 24, 36, 44, of *Strange Happenings* 2. What is happening in each of the pictures?
3. Where are the events taking place?
4. Describe the lady and the boy in the picture on page 3.
5. Discuss and share with your friend.

Activity 4 – work in pairs

1. Look at the picture on page 51, 69, 75, 81 and 88 of *Strange Happenings*
2. What is happening in each of the pictures?
3. Where are the events taking place?
4. Describe the lady and the girl and boy in the picture on page 51.
5. Discuss and share with your friend.

Home activity

Draw a chart or timetable showing targets and how you will read the novella.

Your teacher will direct you and your parent or guardian will guide you.

Key learning insights:

- Reading entails taking time to observe and learn something. It means opening a book to look at the words written (story) and pictures shown in order to get the message or subject matter contained in the text.
- Reading helps learners to develop and acquire reading skills. It enhances comprehension and critical thinking skills.
- Reading enables learners to acquire, learn and expand their vocabulary and language. It exposes learners to language skills for self-expression and communication.
- Reading stimulates the learner's powers of imagination, inspiring them to visualize and create their own stories.
- Reading encourages learners to practice and appreciate cultural diversity making them more aware, cohesive and accommodative amongst others.

- Reading encourages critical analysis which enhances critical thinking and problemsolving.

Elements of reading, analysis and appreciation of the novella

Activity 3 – work in pairs

1. Study the elements below and discuss the meanings in relation to *Strange Happenings*.
2. Use the novella, *Strange Happenings* to read and make notes.
3. Write short points and share with your classmates.

Element	Meaning
The book cover	this contains the title, pictures and author,
The blurb of the book	a short description of the book at the back cover.
Point of view	the perspective from which the story is told.
The plot of the story	the sequence of events making up the storyline.
Short summary (synopsis)	a brief overview of the book.
Setting of the story	the time and place in which the story takes place.
Exposition	the introduction of the background of the story.
Central conflict of the story	the main struggle that drives the story forward.
Main characters of the story	the major, well-developed figures in the story.
Character and character traits	attributes of personality and behaviour.
Main themes of the story	the underlying issues raised in the story.
Major style of the story	the authors' language and writing technique.
Book review	a critical evaluation of how good the book is.

Different parts that aid in previewing a book – 2 lessons

Studying the cover page

Activity 4 – work in pairs

Study the cover page of the novella and answer the following questions.

1. What is the title of the novella?
2. What is the name of the author of the novella?

3. Search on the internet to find out more about the writer of the novella?
4. Identify and describe the pictures on the cover page?
5. Describe what the pictures represent.
6. Write down short notes about the cover page and present in class.

Key learning insights:

- The title of the novella is ***Strange Happenings***. The author's name is **Jennie Marima**. Jennie Marima is a young Kenyan author who has published many storybooks in the children's category including *The High Road*, *Super Sara* and *Lost Baby*.
- The cover page of the novella includes the blue school gate, two learners behind a heap of sand outside the gate, and a visible CCTV camera installed on the perimeter wall fence. At the background are some coastal trees in darkness, giving it a night theme. The moon is also visible in the sky at night.

Reading and describing the blurb

Activity 5 – work in pairs

1. Read the description given at the back page of the cover.
2. What details does the description contain?
3. List some of the details at the back cover.
4. Does it help you to understand what the book is about?
5. Discuss and share experiences with your friends.

Key learning insights:

- The back page of the cover contains the **blurb**. The blurb provides information about the novella. This information helps the reader to know the critical message, language, the main characters and the subject matter of the story, and the setting of the story.
- It is important to read the information on the cover and the blurb.
- The blurb summarises the story and gives an opinion about it.
- It is more necessary to read the whole text for fulfillment and fair evaluation of the book.

Questions to reflect and explore further

1. What is a novella?
2. Who is the author of the novella you have read?
3. The title of the novella you are reading is _____.
4. Identify the pictures shown on the cover of the novella?
5. How fast can you read a novella?
6. What is a blurb?
7. Why should you read the blurb?
8. Explain the value of reading a novella.

Self-Assessment

Use a tick (✓) or (X) to check whether you have learnt the following.

Remember to be honest in whatever you do or say.

- I have read the cover page of *Strange Happenings* by Jennie Marima. _____
- I can tell what a novella is. _____
- I can name the author of the novella. _____
- I have read the blurb of the novella. _____

Setting

Describing the setting of the text

2 lessons

Place and time setting

Activity 6 – work in pairs

1. Read Chapter One, page 1 of *Strange Happenings*.
2. What is the name of the school where the new learner is being admitted to?
3. Where is the school in *Strange Happenings* located? Name the places involved.
4. Does the place change?
5. When do the events happen? State the time in a broad span.
6. Does the time change?
7. Describe the weather of the place at the time.

Key learning insights:

- **Setting** refers to the place and time of the story. It entails where and when the story happens or occurs.
- **The place:** The events in *Strange Happenings* take place in Diani, Pweza Academy at the coastal region of Kenya. Both exciting and strange things happen at Pweza Academy in Diani, south coast, Kwale County bordering the Indian Ocean. This setting shifts between the school and the beach.
- **The time:** the current activities happen during the day and night. However, flashbacks take us back in time when events take place in the recent past after the year 2000 up to the present.
- **Note:** sometimes the setting also includes the weather, mood or the general atmosphere of the environment. For instance, when Mwawasi gets admitted at Pweza Academy, the weather is very hot. “The afternoon sun was drilling fiercely through my head. If I stayed outside any longer, my brain would transform into *nyama choma*.” (p2)

Core Competencies to be developed:

Learning to Learn is enhanced as learners build on their learning experiences through analysis of the setting and research on the author.

Critical thinking is developed as learners explore the links between different events through tasks like creating graphic organisers that cultivate high-order thinking skills.

Problem-solving is archived as learner conducts research online to obtain more information about the author and the setting of the story.

Pertinent and Contemporary Issues (PCIs)

Creative thinking is developed as the learner creates charts to summarise what they have learned.

Values: Unity is enhanced as the learner develops skills for working in harmony with others while participating.

Link to other subjects: The learner relates the skill of intensive reading to their reading of class readers in Kiswahili.

Self-assessment

Use a tick (✓) or (X) to check whether you have learnt the following.
Remember to be honest in whatever you do or say.

- I can tell the place where events take place. _____
- I can tell the time when events take place. _____
- I can describe the weather and atmosphere. _____ ☐ I can describe the setting of the novella. _____

Identifying the main characters in novella – 2 lessons

Key Inquiry Questions

1. Who is a character in a story?
2. How can you tell the difference between a main and a minor character in a story?
3. How would you describe the behaviour of your classmates?

By the end of the analysis the learner should be able to:

- a) Identify the main characters in a class reader,
- b) Explain how the characters make the story flow,
- c) Make predictions based on the title and the sections read,
- d) Appreciate the role of characters in the class reader.

Who is a character in a story?

Activity 1 – work in groups

1. Read Chapter One of *Strange Happenings*, (page 2 – 7).
2. Is the narrator involved in this section? What is the name of the narrator?
3. Who else is mentioned in the chapter you have read? Circle the name in the section.
4. Read Chapter Two of *Strange Happenings*, (page 8 – 12).
5. Identify the main characters. What is the name of the new learner being admitted at the school?
6. What is the name of the lady in a skirt suit who stops near the new learner?

Key Learning Insights

- **A character** is a person whom the story is about. The narrator of the story is also a character in that story.
- When animals are involved in the story, they form part of the characters □ The main characters in *Strange Happenings* by Jennie Marima include: ■ Mwawasi, the narrator.
 - Chao, Mwawasi's younger sister.
 - Hamisi, the mysterious man.
 - Ms Kanene, the PHE and teacher of English.
 - Mr. Gogo, the class teacher and teacher of Maths and Kiswahili.
- The **main characters** make the story flow through their actions, interactions, decisions, words, thoughts and emotions.
- The main characters are usually involved in nearly all main events in the story.
- They also drive the story forward by creating suspense, conflicts, turns and twists.
- For instance, the relationship between Mwawasi and his sister Chao shapes the flow of events through their contrasting personalities.
- While Chao is out-going and outspoken, Mwawasi is shy and reserved. Chao is courageous while her brother is introverted and less confident. **By the end of the section, the learner should be able to:**
 - a) Discuss predictions made from the title and the sections read,
 - b) Participate in a reader's theatre and read portions of the class reader,
 - c) Outline the things done by each character studied in the section,
 - d) Discuss how the characters make the story flow,
 - e) Write a summary about how the main characters make the story flow.

Activity 2 – Work in groups

1. Brainstorm the relevance of the title, *Strange Happenings*.
2. What is strange between Mwawasi and Chao when they meet in class?
3. Why do you think Mwawasi resents Chao's behaviour?
4. Who is the younger of the two and in which Grade is each of the siblings?
5. Read Chapter 3 and 4 of *Strange Happenings* and outline what each character does.

Key Learning insights

- Each of the characters is unique. Each has his or her own dreams and goals.
- While Chao is extroverted, Mwawasi is introverted.
- Mwawasi is enthusiastic about sports while Chao aspires to be a leader in future.
- The differences between the two make the story flow by creating suspense.
- Through his strange behaviour, Hamisi creates suspense and makes the story flow.
- The panicky, restless and suspicious nature of Ms Kanene creates suspense and makes the story flow.
- You must illustrate with evidence, each character trait you identify from the text.
- For instance: *Hamisi's tone seemed to have changed. He was sounding more aggressive by the minute. He was not even giving me a chance to respond. ... "Take off your watch," he ordered* (page 39 – 40). These actions and words from Hamisi show that he is **aggressive, cruel, harsh, unkind and harmful**. He is a **dangerous** man.
- Hence, Hamisi can be describe using the given adjectives as follows;
 - Hamisi is **aggressive** because *he changes his tone and becomes more aggressive*.
 - Hamisi is **cruel** because *he orders Mwawasi to take off his watch*.

The role of characters in the novella

Main characters, their roles and traits

Activity 3 – work in pairs

Study the table below. Using “*Strange Happenings*” by Jennie Marima, trace the characters and give illustrations for their roles and character traits.

Main character	Role, traits	Illustrations
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Mwawasi	Protagonist - main character whom the story is centred on. He is keen, observant, inquisitive, cautious, jealous and resentful He is introverted, reserved and shy.	<i>He quickly notices that the signboard is missing</i>
Chao	Protagonist – supporting, guiding and contrasting the main character. She is outspoken, responsible, loving and caring. She is extroverted, courageous and confident.	
Ms. Kanene	Suspicious character in the story She is irresponsible, timid and nervous devious, deceitful	
Hamisi	Antagonist (villain) – Creates conflict and suspense to drive the story forward. He is cunning, mysterious, Cruel, malicious,	

Mr. Gogo	He is calm, neutral, Patient, keen Observant	
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Identifying minor characters in a novella – 2 lessons

Key Inquiry Questions

- 1) How can you tell the difference between main and minor characters?

By the end of the analysis, the learner should be able to:

- a) Identify minor characters in a class reader,
- b) Discuss the relationships between different minor characters in the class reader,
- c) Appreciate the place of minor characters in the class reader.

Minor characters and their roles and traits

Activity 4 – Work in pairs

- 1) Read and identify minor characters in a class reader.
- 2) List all the names of the characters in the novella, *Strange Happenings* by Jennie Marima.
- 3) Search online and offline for words and phrases used to describe relationships between characters.
- 4) Discuss how the characters relate with each other.
- 5) Collaborate with peers, hot seat different minor characters to bring out their relationships,
- 6) Link characters' reactions to the relationships they are in.

Study the table below. Using “*Strange Happenings*” by Jennie Marima, trace the characters and give illustrations for their roles and character traits.

Minor character	Role, traits	Illustrations
Mother	Loving, Caring, fair, neutral, non-partisan	

Father	Reserved, composed, responsible, provident	
The doctor	Kind, Generous	
The school nurse	Patient Helpful	
Acrobats	Skilled, skilful Determined	
Monkeys Colobus baby-monkeys		
Oman Arabs,		
Other learners		

Use the following words and phrases to describe the relationships between characters.

Positive	Negative
----------	----------

Interconnected	Conflicted
Passionate	Strained
Supportive	Resentful
Competitive	Aggrieved
Sociable	Irritable
Caring	Inferior
Friendly	Easily offended
Self-confident	Self-centred

Activity 5 – work in pairs

Study the adjectives provided in the box below. Use them to assign the main and minor characters. Trace illustrations from the novella, *Strange Happenings*.

Kind responsible quiet loving caring helpful hopeful
hardworking skilled talented mindful disturbing
supportive uncooperative observant compassionate
keen generous wise strict determined

- Mwawasi is _____ because _____
- Chao is _____ because _____
- Hamisi is _____ because _____
- Ms Kanene is _____ because _____
- Mr Gogo is _____ because _____

Key Learning Insights

- The **minor characters** in the novella are: mother, father, the doctor, the school nurse, the acrobats and the monkeys. Note that other learners and teachers are passively part of the story. For instance, although their names are not mentioned, the staffroom gossip that Chao overhears comes from the teachers. The class that Chao's brother joins has other learners.

- The minor characters are generally kind and patient. These characters make the story real and relatable.
- The **adjectives** in the table provided can be used to describe character traits.
- You must illustrate with evidence, each character trait you identify from the text.
- For instance *I fiddled with my waterproof sports smart G-shock watch as I waited for the guide's arrival... it was a farewell gift from the doctor who had been attending to me for months... she had also promised that I would one day be well and use it for sports... but I shed a tear when she left* (Chapter 1, page 6) The actions and words the doctor show that she is **generous, kind, hopeful, caring and patient**. This also reveals the relationship between the two characters.
- Hence, the doctor is **kind** and **generous** because she gives Mwawasi, her patient, an expensive sports watch as a gift.
- The letter in Chapter 12, page 72 – 74 reveals the relationship between the siblings, and mother and her children. It also reveals the character traits of the two siblings.

Reflect and explore further

1. The main characters in ***Strange Happenings*** include _____.
2. The minor characters in the novella include _____.
3. Read the mother's letter in Chapter 12, page 72 - 74 and describe her character traits. Use two adjectives to describe mother with illustrations from the letter.
➤ Mother is _____ because _____

Self-Assessment

Use a tick (✓) or (X) to check what you have learnt.

Remember to be honest in whatever you do or say.

- I can identify and name the main characters in the novella. _____
- I can identify and mention some of the minor characters. _____ ☐
- I can describe some of their character traits. _____

Core Competencies to be developed:

Critical thinking is developed as the learner links the relationships between characters in the novella.

Collaboration is enhanced as the learner observes the rules of engagement while engaging in hot seating different minor characters in the class reader to bring out their relationships.

Pertinent and Contemporary Issues (PCIs)

Citizenship is enhanced as the learner discusses the character traits and relationships of the characters in the class reader.

Values: Social justice is developed as the learner discusses the relationships between characters in a class reader.

Link to other subjects: The learner relates the concept of relationship of characters in a class reader to their learning of characterisation in Creative Arts and Sports.

The summary of the novella (synopsis) – 2 lessons

Activity 1 – work in pairs

1. Read the novella, ***Strange Happenings*** by Jennie Marima.
2. Make notes by writing down the main points.
3. Compare your notes with your classmate.
4. Read the synopsis below.
5. Write your synopsis of the novella in three paragraphs.
6. Present your work in class and to your teacher.

Key Learning Insights

- A **synopsis** is a short summary of the whole story.
- A synopsis gives you the main points of the story by capturing the main idea.
- A synopsis tells you what the story is about. It is a brief overview of the story.
- Before you read the synopsis given in this Guide, read the novella, ***Strange Happenings*** by Jennie Marima.

The following is the synopsis of the novella, ***Strange Happenings***.

"Strange Happenings" is a novella written by Jennie Marima. The novella is set in Diani, Pweza Academy at the south coast Kwale County, Kenya. The story revolves around two learners: a boy called Mwawasi and his sister, Chao.

Mwawasi joins Pweza Academy after spending a long time in hospital because of a football match accident in which his leg is badly injured. To his surprise, the school's signboard is missing. The boy encounters a mysterious person who pretends to work at Pweza Academy. The man known as Hamisi acts in strange ways. Ms Kanene, the teacher of English and PHE also seems suspicious and panicky.

When Ms Kanene takes learners to the beach, Mwawasi is scared to spot Hamisi on the way. While at the beach Hamisi takes him to a very dangerous shack and attempts to rob him of his watch. Before he does, Chao comes to her brother's rescue, calling out the police after giving him first aid. Ms. Kanene swims with the learners, and later comes to look for the boy and girl, undisturbed about their disappearance. The tide gets worse the submerging the walking area as they swim across. Mwawasi collapses and loses memory in the rescue boat. He is dehydrated and stressed.

As Ms. Kanene waits outside the dispensary, she discovers that Chao and Mwawasi are siblings. She pleads with them to conceal the beach secret. Mwawasi and Ms Kanene agree but Chao disagrees. His attitude towards his sister changes as he decides that he would report Hamisi and Ms. Kanene to the class teacher, Mr. Gogo.

Before reporting, Mr. Gogo talks about emergence of a strange flu in China, now spreading across Europe and US. Hamisi guides the two siblings to see the signboard thieves but Mwawasi and Chao see monkeys removing the signboard. They realise that he has vanished when Mr. Gogo arrests them as the thieves. At 6.00 am, Mr Gogo tells them that the first case of Covid-19 has been reported in the country and the school closes indefinitely.

The sequence of events in the novella – 2 lessons

Key Inquiry Questions

- 1) What is the sequence of events in a story called?
- 2) What marks the climax of a story?
- 3) How does the story keep changing?
- 4) What causes the conflict in the story?

Specific Learning Outcomes

By the end of the sub strand the learner should be able to:

- a) Explain the sequence of events in a class reader,

Activity 1 – Work in groups

- 1) Read sections of ***Strange Happenings*** and explain the sequence of events,
- 2) Work with peers to dramatise parts of ***Strange Happenings*** for clarity,
- 3) Outline the actions of each character studied in the section,
- 4) Discuss, how the characters make the story in the class reader flow,

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- 5) Use a sequence chart to show the order of events in *Strange Happenings*,

Key Learning Insights

- The events in the story or novella are organized in a sequence.
- The sequence of events is called **plot**.
- The arrangement, series or order of the events may be linear.
- Sometimes the events may include flashbacks.
- **Flashbacks** are past memories brought into the story. For instance, in this story, Chapter 3, *The Backstory* is a **flashback**. It tells us how the boy got into his current condition.
- In the case of this analysis, the plot of *Strange Happenings* comprises two parts: Part One and Part Two, with seven and eight chapters respectively. The chapters have chapter headings.
- For instance, Chapter One is about ‘*The missing Signboard*.’ The heading of Chapter Two is *Deskmate* while in Chapter Three the heading is ‘*The Backstory*’.
- These chapter headings or titles help to trace the sequence and flow of events in the novella.
- The structure and sequence of events in a story include the following:
 - **Exposition** - introduction and description of events.
 - **Setting** – the time, place and weather.
 - **Plot** – the beginning, the middle and the end of the story.
 - **Introduction** of characters, their traits and description.
 - **Inciting or rising** action – the building up or development of the problem.
 - **Conflict** and **Climax** – the greatest struggles which lead to tension, turns and twists.
 - **End – Falling** action and Resolution (conclusion of the story).
- **Central conflict** in the novella, *Strange Happenings* involves the struggle between two parties: the siblings, Mwawasi and Chao on one hand, and the gang of two, Hamisi and Ms Kanene on the other.
- The sequence also involves a series of events with strange happenings. The strange happenings keep the story flowing through a number of challenges and problems that create suspense.

Activity 2 – work in groups

1. What are the challenges between the main characters?
2. What are the turns and twists in the story?
3. How are the characters different from each other?
4. Why do the characters disagree often?
5. Compare and contrast the main characters in the story.

Key learning insights

- At first, Mwawasi and Chao have some kind of conflict.
- Mwawasi is introverted and shy while Chao is extroverted and courageous.

- Being the elder of the siblings, Mwawasi suffers from low self-esteem now worsened by the accident and repeating of Grade Seven.
- Chao is outgoing and outspoken, something Mwawasi calls know-it-all tendency.
- Mwawasi resents it but later discovers that her sister is uniquely different and gifted.
- On the other hand, Ms Kanene is different from Mr. Gogo. It is said that she misses classes and acts irresponsibly throughout her service at Pweza Academy.
- Ms. Kanene seems to be working with Hamisi and they could be up to some mischief.
- Similarly, mother and father are different. While mother does much to care for her injured son, the father, a man of few words cautiously warns the boy against jumping for there is no money for hospital bills.
- These differences can be appreciated and rewarded if they are positive while the negative ones exhibited by Kanene and Hamisi should be reprimanded and punished.

Climax of the story

— 2 lessons

Key Inquiry Question

1. What marks the climax of a story?

Specific Learning Outcomes

- a) Make short notes on the sequence of events in a class reader,
- b) Appreciate reading works of art for information and enjoyment.

Activity 1 – work in groups

1. Read chapters 10 to 15 of *Strange Happenings*.
2. What are the turning points of the problems encountered?
3. Make short notes on the sequence of events in the section reader,
4. Relate the events in the class reader to real life.
5. Discuss possible solutions to the problems portrayed in the class reader.

Key Learning Insights

- The **climax** is the turning point which leads to the resolution of the conflict.
- The resolution includes Mwawasi's resolve to work with her sister, to report Hamisi and Ms Kanene to the Class teacher and unearth the signboard thieves.
- The climax of the novella, *Strange Happenings* is when the mysterious Hamisi decides to show the siblings the signboard thieves who happen to be monkeys.
- This overturns when he disappears leaving them arrested by Mr. Gogo as the signboard thieves. Then suddenly everything tilts to a sudden halt when the first case of Covid-19 is reported in the country and all schools are directed to close indefinitely.
- The challenges and problems portrayed by in *Strange Happenings* should be resolved.
- The issues of safety, theft and kidnapping can be addressed through investigations and police interventions.

- Accidents, low self-esteem, pessimism and crime can be addressed through awareness creation, guidance and counselling.

Chapter reading, analysis and assessment

Activity 1 – work alone

Use the table below to reflect, explore and assess yourself.

Chapter _____ Date _____

Main characters	Main events	Themes	Style

Self-assessment

Use a tick (✓) or (X) to check what you have learnt.

Remember to be honest in whatever you do or say.

- I have read Part 1 and 2 of *Strange Happenings* by Jennie Marima. _____
- I can describe the sequence of events in the novella. _____
- I can explain conflict in the novella. _____
- I can identify the climax of the story. _____

Core Competencies to be developed:

Collaboration is enhanced as the learner participates actively in dramatising parts of the class reader for conceptualisation.

Critical thinking and **problem-solving** are developed as the learner comes up with possible options as solutions to problems the problems portrayed in the class reader.

Pertinent and Contemporary Issues (PCIs)

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Ethical relationships are enhanced as the learner relates issues of relationships in the class reader to real life.

Values: Respect is enhanced as the learner respects diverse opinions while working with peers to dramatise parts of the class reader.

Link to other subjects: The learner relates performance skills to the concept of performance techniques in Creative Arts and Sports.

Part one: summary of sequence of events (table)

Activity 1 – work in groups

Study the summary table below and discuss the events in each chapter.

Chapter	Main events and characters	Page
1	The missing signboard □ The boy, Mwawasi is admitted to Pweza Academy.	1 – 7
	• Ms Kanene and Hamisi the ‘mysterious Guide’ □ The School signboard is missing. • It is strange that the signboard is missing. • It is strange how Ms Kanene leaves Mwawasi waiting to be shown the dormitory but does to bother to follow up.	
2	Desk-mate • Mr. Gogo, the class teacher shows Mwawasi where to sit. • He sits in the middle row, and his deskmate is Chao, coincidentally, his sister. • It is strange that Mwawasi finds the new desk-mate to be his sister, Chao.	8 –12

3	The Back story • The boy is involved in an accident during games, a football match in which he injures his leg badly when he attempts to tackle an opponent in his former school. (p13) • The boy walks on crutches due the accident injury. He has been in hospital for months • Mr. Gogo triples up as the class teacher and teacher of Mathematics and Kiswahili. • Mr. Gogo comes to and appoints Chao the class secretary for she is outspoken. • It is strange that Mwawasi is denied admission in other schools but admitted at Pweza Academy where the sister, Chao is.	13 – 17
4	The Beach • Mwawasi’s attitude towards towards Chao because of being a know-it-all. • Ms. Kanene, teacher of English and PHE takes the learners to the beach on school’s beach day. • Mwawasi spots Hamis and waves at him on their way to the beach. • The two, Mwawasi and Chao, sit together. Chao asks who Hamisi is. • She dismisses his existence in their school. • It is strange that the care-taker, Hamisi is non-existent.	18 – 25
5	Hamisi • At the beach – Mwawasi watches as the learners and Ms Kanene swim • Then, Hamisi comes into view and Mwawasi follows Hamisi • Mwawasi asks Hamisi whether he works at Pweza Academy but Hamisi just laughs. • It is strange how Hamisi happens to be at the beach.	26 – 32

6	Her Brother's Keeper • Hamisi takes Mwawasi to the ruins five-star hotel that is closed due to the 2007 post-election violence. • Mwawasi and Hamis watch and witness acrobatic shows at the ruins • They also witness caged baby-monkeys for bush meat. • It is strange that monkeys are reared and caged for meat. • Hamisi takes Mwawasi to a very dangerous room and orders him to take off his watch. Before this happens, Chao calls out Mwawasi to find out where he is. • It is strange how Hamisi suddenly orders Mwawasi to take off his watch	33 – 40
7	Are we in Trouble? • At the ruins – in bad thoughts, Mwawasi explains that Hamisi wants to rob him of his watch. • Hamisi then disappears miraculously. • They leave the ruins swimming across the submerged walking area. • Chao is tossed back to the water (sea), attempting to clutch on the boy with crutches. • Mwawasi is in panic for he has sneaked into unauthorized territory. • He collapses and loses memory due to congestion. • It is strange how Hamisi vanishes mysteriously from the scene.	41 – 47

Part two: summary of sequence of events (table)

Activity 1 – work in groups

Study the summary table below and discuss the events in each chapter.

Chapter	Main Events and characters	Page
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8	Back to Square One • Mwawasi recollects his hospital experience • Chao asks the school nurse about the existence of Hamisi in school. • The nurse tells Chao he used to work there but currently not for he retired three years ago and even a party thrown for him. • The nurse uses FaceBook to show the two Hamisi's photos as a 60-year-old man. • The nurse wants to know why they enquire but Chao says it is a long story. • Chao asks Mwawasi whether it is the same Hamisi but he denies • It is strange that the person shown on FaceBook photo is different from the one they are talking about. • It is strange they have to go back to square one for they have unearthed nothing substantial.	49 – 54
9	The Conspiracy • Ms. Kanene waits outside the dispensary, afraid that the two would reveal the secret of the beach trip. • Ms Kanene just discovers that Chao and Mwawasi are siblings. • Ms. Looks around and pleads with them to conceal the beach secret. • Mwawasi and Ms Kanene agree but Chao disagrees.	55 – 60
	• Chao and Mwawasi argue (tiff) • It is strange that a teacher can hide the truth, covering Hamisi	

10	The suspect • Chao and Mwawasi do not talk to each other due to the tiff between them. • Mwawasi is humbled, accepts, apologises and admires Chao, his sister immensely. • Mwawasi decides that he would report Hamisi to the class teacher, Mr. Gogo. • Mwawasi requests to talk to Mr. Gogo after the Maths lesson.	61 – 64
11	The Betrayal • Before reporting, Mwawasi speaks of strange happenings and Mr. Gogo talks about emergence of a strange flu in China, now spreading across Italy, Spain and US. • Mr. expects to hear Mwawasi's request but Ms Kanene interrupts saying "<i>Hope you will do the right thing</i>" – keeping the secret. She grips him by the shoulder and threatens him. • The decision to report the beach and ruins events was the right thing according to Chao and her brother but not to report is the right thing according to Ms Kanene. (Strange)	65 – 69
12	The Letter • Mother's letter to Chao advises her to take care of her brother because he is in a bad condition since the accident. He misses school and sports, things he likes very much. Being back in school is the closest thing to normal. • The normal school situation <i>has</i> not returned because of the strange happenings. • Chao's note to Mwawasi ("<i>You are doing the right thing, I am so proud of you</i>") encourages him to report the matter about which she had disagreed with Ms Kanene.	70 – 75
13	• The Return • Mwawasi sits somewhere along the path to the toilet, in order to read the mother's handwriting. • Hamisi mysteriously emerges, follows him, blindfolds him, takes him to his house and threatens him not to scream.	76 – 81

	• Hamisi reveals a lot of things about “Yeri” (respected deputy head teacher, retrenched 7 years ago and being the only one to suffer this job loss.) • How he has been reduced to stray dog. Even beach boys chase him... He knows and lurks around the corridors, knows where everything is hidden. If he had wanted to do many bad things to the school, he would do them. He is capable of causing harm but he hasn’t. • With two expensive lawyers he defends his case in court but he loses. • Hamisi promises to show the two siblings the signboard thieves, at 3.00 am.	
14	The Truth • Mwawasi returns to class and finds the lesson is over but gets the much needed information from Hamisi. • Chao tells Mwawasi about the staffroom gossips that Ms Kanene misses classes, neglects the newly admitted girl. • Ms Kanene could be looking for Hamisi first, to take the girl to the dormitory. • The truth is: Ms Kanene and Hamisi have strange deals!	82 – 84

15	The Grand Finale • The two go to see the real stealers of the signboard. • They see monkeys removing the signboard at night. • They tense as Mr. Gogo finds them hiding behind the heap of sand • Yeri has placed the siblings in danger and disappeared • Mr. Gogo tells them they are the thieves and escorts to an empty room next to the staffroom. • At 6.00am Mr. Gogo tells them to forget about the monkeys because there is a more serious problem: first case of Covid-19 is reported in the country. • Mr. Gogo says the school is under official directive to close indefinitely. • He adds they are organizing for transport for all learners back home.	85 – 91
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Plot and chapter notes

PART ONE

Chapter 1- The missing signboard

Activity 1 – work in pairs

1. Read chapter 1 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - The boy, Mwawasi is admitted to Pweza Academy.
 - Ms Kanene hesitates to guide the boy to the dormitory and lets Hamisi the ‘Guide’ do it.
 - The signboard is missing. Strange that the signboard is missing, not once.
 - It is strange how Ms Kanene leaves Mwawasi waiting to be shown the dormitory but does to bother to follow up.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 1 and answer the following questions.

1. Name the characters in this chapter.
2. Where are the events taking place?
3. What time are the events taking place?
4. What is the main event in this chapter?
5. Where is Mwawasi sitting before being escorted to the dormitory?
6. How is Ms Kanene dressed when Mwawasi sees her?
7. How would you describe Mwawasi’s father?
8. Why do you think Mwawasi wishes to be a monkey?
9. Who escorts Mwawasi to the dormitory?

10. Which colour is the school uniform?
11. Mention one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 2 – Desk-mate (p8 – p12)

Activity 2 – work in pairs

1. Read chapter 2 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Mr. Gogo, the class teacher shows Mwawasi where to sit.
 - He sits in the middle row, and his deskmate is Chao, coincidentally his sister.
 - It is strange that Mwawasi finds the new desk-mate to be his sister, Chao.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 2 and answer the following questions.

1. What are some of Mwawasi's wishes?
2. Who is the class teacher of Mwawasi?
3. Which row does Mwawasi sit?
4. Who is Mwawasi's new desk-mate?
5. What is the secret behind Chao and Mwawasi?
6. Why does Mwawasi say that his desk-mate assigning experience is something close to traumatic?
7. How would you describe Chao?
8. Which learning areas does Mr. Gogo teach?
9. Explain one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 3 – The Back story (p13 – p17)

Activity 3 – work in groups

1. Read chapter 3 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - The boy was involved in an accident during games, football match when he attempts to tackle an opponent in his former school. (p13) □ The boy walks on crutches.
 - Mr. Gogo triples up as the class teacher and teacher of Mathematics and Kiswahili.
 - Mr. Gogo comes to and appoints Chao the class secretary for she is outspoken.
 - It is strange that Mwawasi is denied admission in other schools but admitted at Pweza Academy where the sister, Chao is.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 3 and answer the following questions.

1. Why does Mwawasi use crutches?
2. Who does Mr. Gogo appoint the class secretary, and why?
3. Why does Mwawasi repeat the seventh grade?
4. Give two reasons why Mwawasi refers to Chao as the teachers' pet.
5. Describe Mwawasi.

6. Why does Chao and Mwawasi not get along so well? Describe their relationship.
7. Which two things does Chao do when Mr. Gogo enters the class?
8. What does Mwawasi's parents do to cover his medical costs?
9. Mention one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 4 – The Beach (p18 – p25)

Activity 4 – work in pairs

1. Read chapter 4 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Mwawasi's attitude towards Chao because of being a know-it-all.
 - Ms. Kanene, teacher of English and PHE takes the learners to the beach on school's beach day.
 - Mwawasi spots Hamisi and waves at him on their way to the beach.
 - The two, Mwawasi and Chao, sit together. Chao asks who Hamisi is.
 - She dismisses his existence in their school.
 - It is strange that the care-taker, Hamisi is non-existent.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 4 and answer the following questions.

1. Who takes pupils to the beach?
2. Where does Chao sit on the bus during the trip?
3. Who does Mwawasi spot on the road to the beach?
4. Why does Chao deny that Hamisi is one of the workers in school?
5. Describe the appearance of Hamisi without his overall.
6. Why does Mwawasi refer to Diani as a sleepy town?
7. Name one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 5 – Hamisi (p26 – p32)

Activity 5 – work in groups

1. Read chapter 1 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - At the beach – Mwawasi watches as the learners and Ms Kanene swim □ Then, Hamisi comes into sight and Mwawasi follows him.
 - Mwawasi asks Hamisi whether he works at Pweza Academy but Hamisi just laughs □ It is strange how Hamisi happens to be at the beach.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 5 and answer the following questions.

1. Where does the narrow path lead to?
2. What surprises Mwawasi most?
3. What are some of the instructions Mwawasi expects Ms Kanene to give?
4. What does Mwawasi do when other pupils start to swim?

5. Which question does Mwawasi ask Hamisi when he meets him?
6. Mention one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 6 – Her Brother’s Keeper (p33 – 40)

Activity 6 – work in pairs

1. Read chapter 6 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Hamisi takes Mwawasi to the ruins five-star hotel that is closed due to the 2007 postelection violence.
 - Mwawasi and Hamisi watch and witness acrobatic shows at the ruins □ They also witness caged baby-monkeys for bush meat.
 - It is strange that monkeys are reared and caged for meat.
 - Hamisi takes Mwawasi to a very dangerous room and orders him to take off his watch. Before this happens, Chao calls out Mwawasi to find out where he is.
 - It is strange how Hamisi suddenly orders Mwawasi to take off his watch.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 6 and answer the following questions.

1. Where does Hamisi take Mwawasi to?
2. Why do very few Kenyans visit the ruins?
3. What activities do Mwawasi and Hamisi witness?
4. Why are the baby monkeys caged?
5. Why does Mwawasi feel that Hamisi is not his friend?
6. What does Hamisi want to steal from Mwawasi and why?
7. Who prevents Mwawasi’s watch from being stolen?
8. Identify one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 7 – Are we in Trouble? (p41 – p47)

Activity 7 – work in groups

1. Read chapter 7 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - At the ruins – in bad thoughts, Mwawasi explains that Hamisi wants to rob him of his watch.
 - Hamisi then disappears miraculously.
 - They leave the ruins swimming across the submerged walking area.
 - Chao is tossed back to the water (sea), attempting to clutch on the boy with crutches.
 - Mwawasi is in panic for he has sneaked into unauthorized territory.
 - He collapses and loses memory.
 - It is strange how Hamisi vanishes mysteriously from the scene.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 7 and answer the following questions.

1. Where does Hamisi emerge from?
2. What makes Mwawasi stunned?

3. How does the clutch prove useful to Mwawasi?
4. Who helps Chao and Mwawasi get to the other side?
5. Why does Mwawasi collapse while on the boat?
6. Mention one strange happening from this chapter.

Use the table below to reflect, explore and assess yourself in Part One

Chapter _____ Date _____

Main characters	Main events	Themes	Style

PART TWO

Chapter 8 – Back to Square One (p49 – p54)

Activity 8 – work in groups

Read chapter 8 and make short notes.

1. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Mwawasi recollects hospital experience
 - Chao asks the school nurse about the existence of Hamisi in school.
 - The nurse tells Chao he used to work there but currently not for he retired three years ago and even a party thrown for him.
 - The nurse uses FaceBook to show the two Hamisi's photos as a 60-year-old man.
 - The nurse wants to know why they enquire but Chao says it is a long story.
 - Chao asks Mwawasi whether it is the same Hamisi but he denies
 - It is strange that the person shown on FaceBook photo is different from the one they are talking about.
 - It is strange they have to go back to square one for they have unearthed nothing substantial.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 8 and answer the following questions.

1. What makes Mwawasi feel that he is back in hospital?
2. What question does Chao ask the nurse?
3. How old is Hamisi when he retires?
4. Why is Chao and Mwawasi back to square one?
5. Identify one strange happening in from this chapter.

Chapter 9 – The Conspiracy (p55 – p60)

Activity 9 – work in pairs

1. Read chapter 9 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Ms. Kanene waits outside the dispensary, afraid that the two would reveal the secret of the beach trip happenings.
 - Ms Kanene just discovers that Chao and Mwawasi are siblings.
 - Ms. Looks around and pleads with them to conceal the beach secret.
 - Mwawasi and Ms Kanene agree but Chao disagrees. □ Chao and Mwawasi argue (they have a tiff).

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 9 and answer the following questions.

1. Where is Ms Kanene when Chao and his brother are inside the dispensary?
2. Why does Ms Kanene want the desk-mates to keep the secret?
3. Why does Mwawasi suspect Hamisi as the likely thief?
4. Why do the desk-mates disagree?
5. Mention one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 10 – The suspect (p61 – p64)

Activity 10 – work in pairs

1. Read chapter 10 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Chao and Mwawasi do not talk to each other due to the tiff between them. □
 - Mwawasi is humbled, accepts, apologises and admires Chao, his sister immensely □
 - Mwawasi decides that he would report Hamisi to the class teacher, Mr. Gogo. □
 - Mwawasi requests to talk to Mr. Gogo after the Maths lesson.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 10 and answer the following questions.

1. What does Chao want to tell Mwawasi before Mr. Gogo comes in?
2. Which one thing does Mwawasi do that he has never done before?
3. What does Chao write in the note to Mwawasi?
4. What strange happening does Mwawasi notice in the note?

Chapter 11 – The Betrayal (p65 – p69)

Activity 11 – work in groups

1. Read chapter 11 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Before reporting, Mwawasi speaks of strange happenings and Mr. Gogo talks about emergence of a strange flu in China, now spreading across Italy, Spain and US.
 - Mr. expects to hear Mwawasi's request but Ms Kanene interrupts saying "***Hope you will do the right thing***" – keeping the secret. She grips him by the shoulder and threatens him.
 - The decision to report the beach and ruins events was the right thing according to Chao and her brother but not to report is the right thing according to Ms Kanene. (Strange)

Questions to Reflect on and explore further

Read chapter 11 and answer the following questions.

1. How learning areas does Mr. Gogo handle?
2. What does Mwawasi want to report to Mr. Gogo?
3. What mysterious happenings does Mr. Gogo mention?
4. Why does Mwawasi not report Hamisi to Mr. Gogo?
5. Why does Ms Kanene threaten Mwawasi?
6. Mention one more strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 12 – The Letter (p70 – p75)

Activity 12 – work in pairs

1. Read chapter 12 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Mother advises Chao in the letter to take care of his brother because he is in a bad condition since the accident.
 - He misses school and taking part in sports, things he likes very much. Being back in school is the closest thing to normal. The normal school situation *has* not returned because of the strange happenings.
 - Chao's note to Mwawasi ("***You are doing the right thing, I am so proud of you***") encourages him to report the matter about which she had disagreed with Ms Kanene.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 12 and answer the following questions.

1. What is Chao looking for at the desk?
2. Why is Mwawasi curious to read the letter and how does he go about it?
3. When does Mwawasi read the letter?
4. What is the letter about?
5. Identify one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 13 – The Return (p76 – p81)

Activity 13 – work in groups

1. Read chapter 13 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Mwawasi sits somewhere along the path to the toilet, to read the mother's letter.

- Hamisi mysteriously emerges, follows him, blindfolds him, takes him to his house and threatens him not to scream.
- Hamisi reveals a lot of things about “Yeri” (respected deputy head teacher, retrenched 7 years ago and being the only one to suffer this job loss.)
- How he has been reduced to stray dog. Even beach boys chase him... He knows and lurks around the corridors, knows where everything is hidden. If he had wanted to do many bad things to the school, he would do them. He is capable of causing harm but he hasn’t.
- With two expensive lawyers he defends his case in court but he loses.
- Hamisi promises to show the two siblings the signboard thieves, at 3.00 am.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 13 and answer the following questions.

1. How does Mwawasi feel after reading the letter?
2. What happens to Mwawasi before he leaves the place he is?
3. What is the real name of Hamisi?
4. Narrate the events that befell Hamisi 7 years ago.
5. What is strange about Yeri’s retrenchment?

Chapter 14 – The Truth (p82 – p84)

Activity 14 – work in pairs

1. Read chapter 14 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - Mwawasi returns to class and finds the lesson is over but gets the much needed information from Hamisi.
 - Chao tells Mwawasi about the staffroom gossips that Ms Kanene misses classes, neglects the newly admitted girl.
 - Ms Kanene could be looking for Hamisi first, to take the girl to the dormitory.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 14 and answer the following questions.

1. What gossip does Chao tell her desk-mate brother?
2. When are the desk-mate siblings supposed to meet with Yeri and why?
3. Mention one strange happening from this chapter.

Chapter 15 – The Grand Finale (p85 – p91)

Activity 15 – work in groups

1. Read chapter 15 and make short notes.
2. Compare your notes with the following.
 - The two siblings go to see the real stealers of the signboard.
 - They see monkey removing the signboard at night.
 - They tense as Mr. Gogo finds them hiding behind the heap of sand
 - Yeri has placed them in danger and disappeared

- Mr. Gogo tells them they are the thieves and escorts to an empty room next to the staffroom.
- At 6.00am Mr. Gogo tells them to forget about the monkeys because there is a more serious problem: Covid-19 first case is reported in the country.
- Mr. Gogo says the school is under official directive to close indefinitely.
- He adds that they are organizing for transport for all learners back home.

Reflect and explore further

Read chapter 15 and answer the following questions.

1. How does Yeri help Chao and Mwawasi to get out of the dormitory and the school compound undetected?
2. Who are the thieves who steal the school signboard?
3. How are the desk-mates found in the dark scenario?
4. Where are the desk-mates taken to by Mr. Gogo?
5. What is the most important case apart from that of the desk-mates?
6. Mention one strange happening from this chapter.

Use the table below to reflect, explore and assess yourself on Part Two

Chapter _____ Date _____

Main characters	Main events	Themes

Themes —

The central message — 2 lessons

Key inquiry question

1. What is a theme?
2. How can you identify a theme in a story?

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3. How do the characters reveal themes?

Specific Learning outcomes

By the end of the sub strand, the learner should be able to:

- a) Identify themes from a selected text,
- b) Analyse the positive and negative aspects of the central themes,
- c) Appreciate the value of themes in a work of art.

What is a theme?

Activity 1 – Work in pairs

1. Read page 16 of Chapter 3. What is Mwawasi struggling with?
2. Write down the main issues raised by Mwawasi.
3. Read chapter 11 of *Strange Happenings*
4. What is the chapter about?
5. What are the major problems evident in the story?
6. What is the main issue the character is struggling with?
7. What do you learn from the chapter?
8. What is the moral lesson?

Activity 2 – work in groups

Complete the following table using the given abstract nouns and phrases (themes).

Theme (abstract noun)	Character revealing it	Illustration
1. Courage		
2. Crime		
3. Self-confidence		

4. Low self-esteem		
5. Pain of injury		
6. Leadership		
7. Family relations		

Activity 3 – work in pairs

1. Read the following sentences from Chapter 3, page 14 of ***Strange Happenings***.
2. State the themes present in them.
3. Discuss in pairs.
4. Trace the sentences in the novella, ***Strange Happenings*** by Jennie Marima.
 - a. *Now I had to repeat the Seventh Grade.*
 - b. *Despite their best efforts, my parents could not find a school that could accommodate me.*
 - c. *I can tell you for sure that few things are as painful as going to the same school and the same class as your younger sister, whom you had managed to avoid your whole life.*
 - d. *I walked with a plastered leg and a crutch, meaning I was significantly slower than everyone else.*
 - e. *As an athlete, not being able to participate in sports was a pain I could not describe.*
 - f. *My basket of problems was already full.*
 - g. *A nurse came in shortly. Just the sight of her brought sadness. I was so tired of doctors, nurses and hospitals.*
5. Identify and explain the issues raised (themes) in the above sentences.

Key Learning Insights

- A **theme** is the central message containing a moral issue and a moral lesson.
- It is what the story is about or simply the subject matter of the story.
- A theme can be present in a paragraph, chapter, story or throughout the novella.

- A theme communicates to the reader the problems or challenges facing characters and how they deal with them in their day-to-day life.
- There also may be positive aspects of life that characters may be experiencing from time to time. The moral issue is usually entrenched in the theme and the values are encouraged through the theme. A theme with the moral value is rewarded while a theme with a vice, such as drug abuse, corruption or crime is reprimanded and punished.
- Themes are stated using abstract nouns such as ‘crime,’ and noun phrases, such as ‘the pain of injury.’
- Themes such as friendship, courage, adventure, mystery, family, self-confidence, kindness, empathy and discovery usually relate with the learner’s experiences and captivate the young readers’ imaginations.
- In ***Strange Happenings***, the theme of courage is revealed through Chao. Chao shows confidence throughout the novella. For instance, Mr. Gogo, the class teacher appoints her the class secretary because she acts very fast to rub the board during a Maths lesson. She also acts very fast and responsibly to rescue her elder brother despite being the younger of the two.
- The themes of self-confidence, self-esteem, the pain of injury, family relationship, leadership, decision-making, mystery and crime are at the centre of the novella, ***Strange Happenings***.

Self-assessment

Use a tick (✓) or (X) to check what you have learnt.

Remember to be honest in whatever you do or say.

- I have read Part 1 and 2 of *Strange Happenings* by Jennie Marima. _____
- I can identify the main themes in the novella. _____
- I can identify and illustrate the theme of family love. _____
- I can identify and illustrate the theme of pain and injury. _____

Features of style

— 2 lessons

Key Inquiry Questions

1. What is style?
2. Why do we use stylistic devices in writing?

Specific Learning Outcomes

By the end of the sub strand, the learner should be able to:

- d) Identify instances of dialogue, similes, and metaphors in the text,
- e) Use the styles of dialogue, similes, and metaphors in guided context,

- f) Appreciate the importance of style in a work of art.

Designer/illustrator: Insert a picture showing two different car models/shapes eg Premio and ProBox

Activity 1 – Work in pairs

1. Look at the shapes of the cars shown in the picture.
2. Describe the shapes of the cars?
3. Imagine the cars are of different colours. What colours do you think of?
4. Which cars would you admire or like to buy?
5. How would you describe the cars?
6. Read these words from the novella. “*I fiddled with my waterproof sports smart G-shock watch as I waited for the guide’s arrival...*” (Chapter 1, page 6)
7. How is the watch described? Discuss and share our experiences with your classmates.

Activity 2 – work in pairs

1. Read the class novella, ***Strange Happenings***.
2. Identify with illustrations, instances of dialogue, similes, and metaphors used in the text.
3. Write them down and display your work on the class notice boards.
4. Extract and write down the dialogue sections of the novella such as the conversation between Mwawasi and Hamisi on page 7.
5. Write the heading “Conversation between Mwawasi and Hamisi”
6. Write the names of characters on the left in capitals followed by colons.
7. Extract all the spoken words in quotation marks and place them after the colons.
8. Act out the conversation in the novella in class.

Activity 3 –work in pairs

1. Role-play selected **dialogues** from the class reader such as the conversation between Chao and Mwawasi on page 25.
2. Let one learner be Chao and the other Mwawasi in the dialogue on page 25.
3. Act out the dialogue or read it dramatically.
4. Record yourself for video sharing and review.
5. Make sentences using the similes and metaphors identified from the text.
6. Identify the use of flashbacks in the novella, such as *The Backstory* and Mwawasi’s flashbacks of Hamisi in Chapter 4 on page 25.
7. Discuss instances in real life where dialogues, similes, and metaphors can be used.
8. Discuss and explain why stylistic devices are used in the novella.

Activity 4 – work in groups

1. Read the novella, Chapter of ***Strange Happenings*** 4, page 18 – 19.

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2. Identify the adjectives used in the description of the beach place, and the characters Chao and Ms Kanene.
3. Discuss and share your experiences in class.

Key Learning Insights

- **Style** is the manner in which something is made. A car may be made to look more attractive than another but it still remains to be a car. Each car model is different from others. Similarly, in a story, a writer may choose to add beauty by changing its shape using different techniques called **style**. Hence, **style** in literature is how the story is narrated or told.
- **Stylistic devices** are used to add beauty to the story and make it more interesting. They also appeal to the emotions, create connections and make the story easy to remember.
- **Examples of stylistic devices** include dialogue, flashback, simile and metaphor.
- In *Strange Happennings*, there occurs a dialogue between Mwawasi and Chao, Hamisi and Mwawasi, Mr. Gogo and Mwawasi, Chao, Mwawasi and Ms Kanene.
- **Similes** are comparisons of two things or people using words “...as” and, “...like...”
- Examples of similes from the novella include: “*tossed in the air like an impala*”, “*Diani felt like a sleepy town*,” “*...like she was showing off her knowledge*”, “*I felt like the wind took my voice...*”, “*like a stray dog*”, “*...hyena-like laughter*”, “*Yeri was like a ghost.*” (pages 22,26,31,35,37,85)
- **Similes** make the story more interesting and engaging. They create vivid mental images that enhance a better understanding of the text.
- **Metaphors** are direct comparisons of two things. For example, “*If I stayed outside any longer, my brain would transform into **nyama choma*** (page 2), ‘*This is not the **wildebeest migration**,*’ (p19), ‘*I **limped** to the secluded area...*’ (Pages 21, 72). The words and phrases in bold show the direct comparisons to the brain, running in corridors and Mwawasi’s movement respectively.
- **Metaphors** also create vivid mental pictures that convey emotions and imaginations, making the story more exciting and memorable.
- The **descriptions** – “large green metallic suitcase”, “oversized grey work overalls,” Beach description, (page 27) “*I fiddled with my waterproof sports smart G-shock watch as I waited for the guide’s arrival...*” (Chapter 1, page 6) are examples of stylistic devices
- **Dialogue** are conversations. They make the story dramatic while revealing feelings, personalities and character traits.
- **Flashbacks** are past memories brought into the story. For instance, in this story, Chapter 3, *The Backstory* is a **flashback**. It tells us how the boy got into his current condition. □ Other examples of stylistic devices are shown in the table below.

Themes versus styles

Activity 3 – work in pairs

Use the table and identify with illustrations from the novella, instances of the themes and style shown.

Themes – what is the story about?	Styles – how is language used?
The main concerns or issues the story is about include: • Personality, trust • Environment, health, pain • Child rights, abuse, labour • Safety, injury, kidnapping	The author describes characters and events through: • Imagery – Simile, Metaphor • Dialogue • Flashback • Description
☐ Adventure, recreation, freedom ☐ Friendship, family relations ☐ Courage, self-confidence ☐ Education, learning abilities ☐ Poverty, crime ☐	☐ Personification ☐ Proverb/idiom ☐ Exaggeration ☐ Irony, ☐ Allusion ☐

Use the table below to reflect, explore and assess yourself on style

Chapter _____ Date _____

Main events	Main themes	Style

Some of the strange happenings in the novella – 2 lessons

Activity 1 – work in groups

1. Read the following mysterious events in the novella.
2. Trace them in the novella and discuss what they critically mean.
 - It is strange how Ms Kanene leaves Mwawasi waiting to be shown the dormitory but does to bother to follow up.
 - It is strange that Mwawasi finds the new desk-mate to be his sister, Chao.

- It is strange that Mwawasi is denied admission in other schools but admitted at Pweza Academy where the sister, Chao is.
- It is strange that the care-taker, Hamisi is non-existent. □ It is strange how Hamisi happens to be at the beach □ It is strange that monkeys are reared or caged for meat.
- It is strange how Hamisi suddenly orders Mwawasi to take off his watch
- It is strange how Hamisi vanishes mysteriously from the scene. It is strange that Ms. Kanene does not question their messing.
- It is strange that the person shown on FaceBook photo is different from the one they are talking about.
- It is strange they have to go back to square one for they have unearthed nothing substantial.
- Why does Ms Kanene want the beach happenings kept secret, strange?

Core Competencies to be developed:

Self-efficacy is developed as the learner holds a discussion on instances in real life where dialogues, similes, and metaphors can be used, thereby enhancing their literary skills.

Learning to learn is achieved as the learner interacts with technology when recording and sharing videos of selected dialogues from the class reader.

Pertinent and Contemporary Issues (PCIs)

Critical thinking is achieved as the learner relates use of the features of styles in real life.

Values: Respect is enhanced as the learner appreciates others when role-playing selected dialogues.

Link to other subjects: The learner relates features of style in the study of class readers to the learning of readers in Kiswahili.

Assessment Rubrics for Reading

Use the table below to make standard assessments for the learner

INDICATOR	(4) EXCEEDING EXPECTATIONS	(3) MEETING EXPECTATIONS	2APPROACHING EXPECTATIONS	1) BELOW EXPECTATIONS
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Ability to read 100 words per minute, accurately and with expressions	Reads 100 words per minute in varied texts, accurately and with expressions. Pauses are natural and has a native speaker like tendencies	Reads 100 words per minute, accurately and with expressions	Reads 50 words per minute, with hesitations and lacks appropriate expressions in some instances	Reads less than 30 words per minute with difficulty and without appropriate expressions
Ability to read for meaning, details and makes inferences	Reads for meaning, details and makes inferences from varied texts	Reads for meaning, details and makes inferences	Reads for meaning and details but does not make inferences	Reads only for meaning but not details and does not make references
Ability to analyse, poems, class reader	Analyses poems, class reader. Evaluates attitude of the speaker and brings out mood in varied texts	Analyses poems and class reader	Analyses poems and class reader that have been practiced	Analyses only poems, class reader with visuals

Answers to ‘Reflect and Explore’ exercises

PART ONE

Chapter 1

Expected responses

1. *Ms Kanene, Hamisi*
2. *Pweza Academy*
3. *Day time*
4. *Admission*
5. *Outside admin block*
6. *A man of few words*
7. *They were free and playful*
8. *Hamisi*
9. *White shirtss and blouses and sky-blue shorts and dresses*
10. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 2

Expected responses

1. *His leg to heal completely and not to repeat the same Grade*

2. *Mr. Gogo*
3. *Diani*
4. *Chao*
5. *They are siblings, brother and sister*
6. *Because chao is a know-it-all girl, extrovert*
7. *Outspoken and extroverted*
8. *Maths, Kiswahili*
9. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 3

Expected responses

1. *He had an accident during a football match*
2. *Chao, she is active*
3. *He had an accident and missed a lot in classwork. He is more talented as an athlete (in sports), no school could accommodate him.*
4. *He thinks she is a know-it-all, she pretends to help the teacher, she raises her hand often and volunteers too much.*
5. *Jealous, shy reserved and introverted boy.*
6. *He resents her outspokenness and know-it-all tendencies.*
7. *She rubs the board, etc*
8. *They sold their pick-up*
9. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 4

Expected responses

1. *Ms Kanene*
2. *Next to her brother and desk-mate*
3. *Hamisi*
4. *Because they had been introduced to staff members*
5. *Thinner*
6. *Small malls*
7. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 5

Expected responses

1. *The public beach*
2. *of old rugged stairs*
3. *Do not wander away from the rest, be back this time*
4. *? Sits on the stairs to watch*
5. *Whether he works at Pweza*

6. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 6

Expected responses

1. *The Hotel ruins*
2. *It is expensive to afford*
3. *Acrobatic shows*
4. *For bush meat*
5. *He suddenly wants to rob him of his watch*
6. *The watch, it is expensive*
7. *Chao, his sister*
8. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 7

Expected responses

1. *The window*
2. *The tide*
3. *Shallow water*
4. *Two fishermen*
5. *Congestion, exhaustion*
6. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

PART TWO

Chapter 8

Expected responses

1. *The smell of the dispensary*
2. *If Hamisi works at the school*
3. *60 years old*
4. *They fail to know the real Hamisi*
5. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 9

Expected responses

1. *Outside*
2. *She acts irresponsibly*
3. *He attempts to steal his watch*
4. *Because keeping the secret is wrong, reporting is better*
5. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 10

Expected responses

1. *the staffroom gossip about Ms Kanene*
2. *Raising his hand up in class*
3. *I am so proud of you. You're doing the right thing.'*
4. *Mother's handwriting*

Chapter 11

Expected responses

1. *Two*
2. *Hamisi*
3. *Covid-19*
4. *Ms Kanene threatens him*
5. *To cover herself*
6. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 12

Expected responses

1. *The letter with a note*
2. *Mother's handwriting*
3. *Under the neem tree, (mwarobaini)*
4. *Taking care of Mwawasi*
5. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 13

Expected responses

1. *remorseful*
2. *He's blindfolded*
3. *"Yeri"*
4. *He was retrenched*
5. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 14

Expected responses

1. *Missing lessons and neglecting the girl*
2. *At 3.00 am to see the Signboard thieves in secret*

3. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

Chapter 15

Expected responses

1. *Knows paths and keys*
2. *Monkeys*
3. *They are hiding as told by Hamisi in order to see the signboard thieves*
4. *Next empty room near staffroom*
5. **Covid-19**
6. *Accept any relevant and reasonable response*

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